

Gender, Religion and Caste

Social Science — Civics • Chapter 3 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Democracy doesn't work in a vacuum — it works among people who differ by gender, religion, caste, language. When such differences become political, that's **identity politics**. Sometimes it gives marginalised groups a voice; sometimes it divides society and damages democracy. This chapter examines three such fault-lines — **gender, religion and caste** — and how each plays out in Indian politics.

Gender division and women in politics

Gender division is rarely seen as 'political' — yet it is, because it shapes who has voice in public life. Most societies have a **sexual division of labour** — women do private (household) work, men do public (paid) work. This was challenged by women's movements:

- **Suffragette movement** — fought for women's right to vote (won in UK 1918, USA 1920, India from independence).
- **Feminist movements** — equality in personal, family, work, political life. Reflected in property rights, equal pay, anti-discrimination laws.
- Today, women have made strong gains in education and many professions, but gaps remain.

Inequalities in India:

- Female literacy rate (~65%) lower than male (~82%); fewer girls reach higher education.
- Sex ratio is still skewed — about 919 girls per 1000 boys (2011 census) — partly due to female foeticide.
- Women's wages are lower than men's for equal work in most jobs.
- Crimes against women, harassment, dowry violence are widespread.

Women in politics: India has had a woman President (Pratibha Patil, Droupadi Murmu) and PM (Indira Gandhi). But Lok Sabha women's share has long been ~10-14% (rising to ~14% in 2019). Reservation in **local bodies** (1/3rd seats) has put over 10 lakh women in elected positions — a quiet revolution. The **Women's Reservation Bill** for 33% reservation in Parliament and State Assemblies was finally passed in 2023.

Religion, communalism and politics

Religion can enter politics in three ways:

- **Constructively** — Mahatma Gandhi believed politics should be guided by ethical/moral values from religion. Reform movements within religions seeking equality (Bhakti, Sufi) had political impact.
- **Unequal treatment** — when one religious community is favoured by the state. The **communal politics** of British India (separate electorates) is an example.
- **Communalism** — when religion is treated as the basis of a nation, when one religion is held to be superior, when religious identities replace political/economic ones.

Communalism takes various forms in everyday life: prejudices, stereotypes, religion-based political mobilisation, and at its worst, communal violence/riots. Partition violence of 1947 and the post-Independence communal riots (1984 anti-Sikh, 1992-93 Mumbai, 2002 Gujarat) are tragic reminders.

Indian Constitution's response: secularism means there is no official state religion; Constitution guarantees freedom to profess any religion (or none); state ensures equality of religions; religious discrimination by the state is forbidden. The state can intervene in religion to ensure equality (e.g. ban untouchability, allow temple entry to Dalits).

Caste and politics

Caste is a feature unique to South Asia. Even today, despite urbanisation and modern education, it shapes marriages, social interactions, and politics.

- **Modern factors weakening caste hierarchy:** reformers like Jyotiba Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar; modern occupations; urbanisation; education; constitutional ban on untouchability; secular laws.

- But caste still matters: rural land ownership patterns, access to education, marriage, and even electoral arithmetic.

Caste in politics: parties consider caste while choosing candidates and leaders. Voters too consider caste while voting. But caste is never the only thing — voters also look at performance, party, leader, issues. **No parliamentary constituency has a clear majority of one caste** — every party needs votes from many castes. Excessive reliance on caste alienates other groups.

Politics in caste: politics has, in turn, transformed caste — old hierarchies are being challenged; lower castes have become politically active; constitutional reservations in education, jobs and legislatures have brought a new generation of leaders from formerly-marginalised castes.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Sexual division of labour: women → private/household; men → public/paid work.
- Indian sex ratio ~919 per 1000 (2011 census); literacy: F~65% < M~82%.
- 1/3rd reservation for women in Panchayats; Women's Reservation Bill (33%) for Parliament passed 2023.
- Three uses of religion in politics: constructive (Gandhi), unequal treatment, communalism.
- Indian Constitution → secular state: no state religion, equality of religions, freedom to practise.
- Caste reformers: Jyotiba Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar.
- No constituency has caste-majority; every party needs cross-caste votes.

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